AGES 4–6 · FREE · NO SIGN-UP

Pre-K and kindergarten readiness, for ages 4 to 6.

Letter sounds, counting, comparing, shapes and listening: the foundations kindergarten builds on. Each activity shows the kindergarten standard it relates to, so you can see why it matters.

For grown-ups

Your child can now do more alone, but talking about answers together still helps most.

Standards codes are shown for parents. They show what an activity relates to, not that we are accredited or endorsed.

If an activity feels too hard, drop back to the preschool page. Confidence matters more than speed.

For full lessons, adaptive practice and the parent view, open the learning app. It is also free and needs no account.

11 ACTIVITIES

Things to do together

Each one has a clear purpose, a way to play, and words to use.

PHONICS

Listen: first sound

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Hear the first sound of a spoken word and match it to its letter.

You need

- Magnetic letters

How to play

1. Play the listening game with sound on.
2. Say a word and ask your child to find the letter it starts with.
3. Let them choose a word for you.

Things to say

"Mmmoon starts with /m/. Which letter makes /m/?"

"What sound does your name start with?"

"Can you find something that starts with /t/?"

Take it further

Write the first letter of each family member's name on a fridge list.

Relates to Common Core: `RF.K.2.d` `RF.K.3.a`

LETTER SOUNDS

What does it start with?

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Match pictured words to the letter for their first sound.

You need

- Picture cards or a picture book

How to play

1. Play the game together.
2. Point to pictures in a book and say the first sound.
3. Find the letter on the page.

Things to say

"Ball. /b/ /b/ ball."

"Which letter makes that sound?"

"What else starts with /b/?"

Take it further

Make a letter book: one page per letter, with drawings.

Relates to Common Core: `RF.K.3.a`

PHONOLOGICAL AWARENESS

Rhyme time

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Recognize and produce rhyming words.

You need

- None

How to play

1. Play the rhyming game together.
2. Say a word and take turns finding rhymes, real or silly.
3. Read a Dr. Seuss-style rhyming book and pause before the rhyme.

Things to say

"Cat, bat, hat… what else?"

"Does sun rhyme with run?"

"That's a silly word, but it rhymes!"

Take it further

Make a rhyme chain in the car.

Relates to Common Core: `RF.K.2.a`

COUNTING AND CARDINALITY

Counting up to ten

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Count up to ten objects, saying one number for each.

You need

- Ten small objects
- An egg carton

How to play

1. Play the counting game.
2. Put one object in each egg cup as you count.
3. Ask how many, then how many more to fill ten.

Things to say

"Ten! How did you know?"

"How many more to make ten?"

"Let's count in twos."

Take it further

Count to 20, then to 100 by tens, while waiting in line.

Relates to Common Core: `K.CC.B.4` `K.CC.B.5`

COMPARING NUMBERS

More or fewer?

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Compare two groups and say which has more, fewer or the same.

You need

- Two plates
- Raisins or blocks

How to play

1. Play the sorting game.
2. Put a different number on each plate and ask which has more.
3. Line them up one-to-one to check.

Things to say

"Which plate has more?"

"How can we be sure?"

"Now they're the same. How did we do that?"

Take it further

Play the card game War with cards 1 to 10.

Relates to Common Core: `K.CC.C.6`

NUMBER SENSE

Pairs: even or odd

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Pair up objects to see if a number splits evenly: early work on breaking numbers apart.

You need

- Socks or shoes

How to play

1. Play the even and odd game.
2. Pair up shoes by the door: is one left over?
3. Split six blocks into two equal groups, then try seven.

Things to say

"Does everyone have a partner?"

"One is left over. That's odd."

"Can we share these fairly?"

Take it further

Share snacks fairly between two plates.

Relates to Common Core: `K.OA.A.3`

GEOMETRY

How many sides?

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 2 min

What it builds: Name shapes and describe them by their sides and corners.

You need

- Straws or sticks
- Play dough balls for corners

How to play

1. Play the shapes game.
2. Build a triangle and a square from straws and dough.
3. Count the sides and corners of each.

Things to say

"How many sides does a triangle have?"

"What's the same about a square and a rectangle?"

"What's different?"

Take it further

Build a 3D cube from straws and dough.

Relates to Common Core: `K.G.A.2` `K.G.B.4`

PATTERNS

Counting in twos

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Continue a counting pattern and count on from a number other than 1.

You need

- Pairs of socks

How to play

1. Play the pattern game.
2. Count pairs of socks by twos: 2, 4, 6.
3. Start counting from 4 instead of 1.

Things to say

"2, 4, 6… what comes next?"

"Start at 5 and count on."

"What number comes just before 9?"

Take it further

Hop on a hopscotch grid while counting on.

Relates to Common Core: `K.CC.A.2`

PRINT AWARENESS

Print walk

Off-screen · About 10 min

What it builds: Know that print carries meaning, is read left to right and is made of letters.

You need

- Signs, labels and packaging around you

How to play

1. Point to words on signs and packets and read them aloud.
2. Run your finger under the word from left to right.
3. Ask your child to find letters they know.

Things to say

“This says STOP. How do you know?”

“Which way do we read?”

“Can you find a letter from your name?”

Take it further

Make labels for things in your child’s room together.

Relates to Common Core: `RF.K.1.a` `RF.K.1.d`

LISTENING COMPREHENSION

Listen and retell

Off-screen · About 15 min

What it builds: Listen to a story and retell its main events.

You need

- A picture book

How to play

1. Read the story through once.
2. Ask your child to tell it back using the pictures.
3. Ask one “why” question about a character.

Things to say

“Who was in the story?”

“What was the problem?”

“Why do you think she did that?”

Take it further

Act the story out with toys.

Relates to Common Core: `RL.K.2` `SL.K.2`

INDEPENDENCE

School-ready routines

Off-screen · About 10 min

What it builds: Practice the everyday independence kindergarten asks for: coats, bags, lunch boxes and turn-taking.

You need

- Coat, backpack, lunch box

How to play

1. Practice putting on a coat and zipping it.
2. Pack and unpack a backpack.
3. Play a turn-taking board game to practice waiting and losing kindly.

Things to say

“What goes in your bag?”

“Can you open your lunch box by yourself?”

“Whose turn is it?”

Take it further

Visit the school playground before term starts.

> These activities relate to the Head Start Early Learning Outcomes Framework domains of Literacy, Mathematics Development, Language and Communication and Approaches to Learning, and to the Common Core kindergarten standards shown on each card. That is our own mapping, not an official review or endorsement.